

Toum

Lebanese garlic sauce · egg-free emulsion · fluffy white paste that holds stiff peaks

YIELD	ACTIVE	KEY RATIO	STORAGE
~500 g	15–20 min	1 : 4 garlic:oil	4–6 wk fridge

INGREDIENTS

Full batch ~500 g — weigh everything

Garlic cloves peeled, ~4 heads, no green germ	130 g
Neutral oil grapeseed / canola / sunflower — NOT olive	520 g
Fresh lemon juice room temp, strained	60 g
Ice water stabilizes the emulsion	60 g
Kosher salt by weight; helps break down garlic	6 g

Toum is an egg-free emulsion — the garlic’s own water plus lemon juice suspend the oil droplets, so the **1 : 4 garlic-to-oil ratio (by weight)** is non-negotiable: too much oil too fast and it breaks. **Never olive oil** — it’s bitter and dyes the toum yellow; neutral oil lets the garlic stay clean and white. The **ice water keeps the processor cool** (heat breaks emulsions) and fresh, firm garlic carries more water for a stronger set.

QUALITY TARGETS

What each stage should look like

STAGE	TARGET
Garlic paste	Smooth, no chunks
Initial emulsion	Creamy, opaque — processor cool to the touch
Final texture	Holds stiff peaks, bright white
Flavor (day 2+)	Mellow, not harsh — rests into balance

Build the Emulsion

METHOD

~10–12 min of patient streaming — don't rush the first oil

- 1 **Prep:** peel the garlic, slice each clove lengthwise and **remove the green germ** (it's the source of bitterness). A small food processor (~3-cup) works best.
- 2 **Paste:** garlic + salt into the processor. Pulse, scrape, then run **1–2 min to a smooth paste** — this is the foundation.
- 3 **Start:** processor running, drizzle the **first ~55 g oil in a hair-thin stream over 2+ min**, then add **15 g lemon**. This is the make-or-break step — do not rush it.
- 4 **Build:** alternate **~55 g oil (slow)** then **15 g ice water or lemon**, repeating until both are used. ~10–12 min total. It turns fluffy and white.
- 5 **Check:** it should **hold stiff peaks, bright white**. Too thick → add ice water; processor warm → pause and let it cool.
- 6 **Rest:** jar it and refrigerate **24 hr minimum** — the harshness mellows and the texture firms.

If it breaks (soupy, separated): start a new batch — 2 fresh garlic cloves + a pinch of salt to a paste, then stream the *broken toum* back in slowly as if it were the oil. **Egg-white rescue** (1 frothy egg white, broken toum streamed in) also works but drops shelf life to 5–7 days. Most breaks come from **oil too fast or a hot processor**.

TROUBLESHOOTING

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Broke / separated	Oil too fast, or processor hot	Re-emulsify into 2 fresh cloves + salt
Too thin	Too much acid, or old garlic	Keep processing, add oil slowly
Too thick	Not enough liquid	Add ice water 15 g at a time
Bitter	Green germ left in, or olive oil	Can't fix — remake, neutral oil, no germ
Too harsh	Fresh garlic, eaten same day	Wait 24–48 hr; or soak garlic 30 min first

SCALING

1 : 4 : 0.46 : 0.46 : 0.046 — garlic : oil : lemon : ice water : salt

BATCH	GARLIC	OIL	LEMON	ICE WATER	SALT
Half ~250 g	65 g	260 g	30 g	30 g	3 g
Full ~500 g	130 g	520 g	60 g	60 g	6 g
Double ~1 kg	260 g	1040 g	120 g	120 g	12 g